

What these new effects will be is hard to imagine. These new technologies allow us to imagine new worlds; to create new selves in this world. In some sense, this idea of digital convergence is the first step towards an unfolding journey that will spark other convergences, many of which we cannot even imagine at this moment.

One of the things that humans have done over the years, as new media have emerged, is play with their capabilities and constraints, and then used them to develop new ways of expressing themselves. These new expressions are ways of developing a deeper understanding of who we are as individuals, as groups (such as organisations or nations) or who we are as a species.

This is a different kind of convergence and is somewhat difficult to explain. Maybe the only way to do is through an example. The beginning of the twentieth century was a time of immense upheaval in our way of understanding our place in the world. In the arena of technology, those early years saw a range of inventions that forever changed the way we lived. These include the airplane, the radio receiver, neon signs, air conditioning, the vacuum diode, colour photography, motion pictures, crossword puzzles, zippers, tommy guns, insulin and the precursor to what we now call television.

And then there were the revolutions in science and art, from relativity theory to cubism, from quantum mechanics to surrealism. Within the space of a few years we moved from a worldview where time and space were absolute, to a relativistic, fractured, unstable one. This change in zeitgeist was reflected in the sciences as well as in the arts.

Consider the year 1922. This was the year that Einstein won the Nobel Prize, James Joyce published *Ulysses*, and T S Eliot published *The Waste Land*. This was also the year that Picasso designed the sets for a ballet performed by Diaghlev and scored by Stravinsky, the debut of which was attended by the likes of James Joyce and Proust.

This kind of a convergence is larger, deeper and more fundamental than the other convergences I have discussed above. In some fundamental way, these convergences, developed a century ago, still define the world we live in today.

It would be foolhardy on my part to even attempt to make predictions about the nature of deep convergence that will emerge from the technological changes happening around us today. Not the least because the effects of technology on society, and of society on technology are complex and multi-threaded. Simple cause and effect relationships are difficult to trace.

Moreover, thinking of such deep convergences can also be risky. At the heart of the word convergence is the word 'verge' with its connotations of being on the edge (as in the leading, or as others say, the bleeding edge).

Being on the verge, or at the edge, is to be somewhere unstable and unpredictable, and this instability can be nerve-racking. There is also a sense of excitement, mingled with fear, mystery and anticipation. There is a realisation that decisions we make today will have ripple effects and consequences, both intended and unintended, far beyond what we can imagine.

The era of digital convergence that this special issue justly celebrates is the culmination of thousands of years of biological and cultural evolution, even as it is the first step in an unfolding process that will yield its fruits in the years and decades to come. ■

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